

CDN Incident Alert: 0049. TLP: CLEAR		Date
Title	DE “Overload” network accounts impersonate German journalists; continue spoofing organisations	23/02/2024

Summary

- Accounts across X and Bluesky continue to post videos spoofing organisations to support specific narratives that directly impact the German election.
- This same network now appears to be posing as journalists to give this content an extra veneer of credibility.
- The content supports a variety of narratives, with the overwhelming majority being anti-Islam and pro-AfD.
- While the network has minimal reach and impact, the activity represents a continual shift in behaviour for the network towards impersonating journalists and inserting false and manipulated content into political discourse.
- The DISARM TTPs used by these accounts are the fabrication of video and audio content (cheap and deepfake); impersonating individuals and institutions; bots amplification and flooding information spaces.
- Recommendations: Archive accounts and content to inform further research; flag accounts with platforms for removal.

Incident

From approx. February 18, 25 accounts spanning X and Bluesky began posting manipulated videos depicting individuals from various organisations and institutions endorsing the AfD. For instance a real video featuring Michael Spence, president of University College London, was manipulated with a voice-over to make it seem he supports “AfD and no one else” in the German elections (1).

Other impersonated individuals are stating disappointment in the German political and security system or discouraging citizens from participating in the election due to the risk of terror attacks. The videos are manipulated to appear as primarily originating from academic institutions or international media, such as a false DW video claiming that “Immigrants in Germany have begun attacking the offices of parties in favour of tougher migration policies and threatening their members” (2). As with previous instances of Overload, posts tag numerous news outlets and the individuals/institutions featured in the videos to make it appear more convincing. Posts on X are accruing hundreds of reposts and likes in a matter of hours, likely from automated bot accounts. Posts are appearing in a variety of languages including German, English, Portuguese, French, and Ukrainian.

Narrative

Meta narrative: German state institutions cannot serve German citizens; radical Islam is overwhelming the West. Sub-narratives: German authorities cannot protect citizens from terrorist attacks; The current German government is inept and unable to deliver results for Germans; Only AfD can save Germany from decline and chaos.

Impact

It is difficult to discern the impact of the Overload network. The aim to flood platforms with noise content and falsified claims is objectively successful. However, as the operation’s methodology employs a cascade of bots and scripted accounts, it is unlikely that the aim is to sway the opinions and behaviour of real users. Instead, Overload appears to be functioning to distract or overwhelm fact-checkers and international observers - backed up by the international scope of institutions and individuals impersonated. The posts are on average gaining 200 likes and shares.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

Objective: [T0139.001: Discourage](#) – Posts aim to discourage election participation with threat of physical harm.

Objective: [T0138.001: Encourage](#) – Twofold: videos encourage viewers to vote for the AfD via endorsement.

Network behaviour encourages fact checkers and analysts to overly engage in the operation.

[T0087.001 Develop AI-Generated Videos \(Deepfakes\)](#) - Videos begin using real talking head footage, before cutting away for [T0087.002: Deceptively Edit Video \(Cheap Fakes\)](#).

[T0087.002 Deceptively Edit Video \(Cheap Fakes\)](#) - Cut away portions of the video use generated voiceovers of the impersonated/edited individuals.

[T0143.003: Impersonated Persona](#) – the deepfakes or cheap fakes are impersonating existing individuals and institutions.

T0049.003: Bots Amplify via Automated Forwarding and Reposting - The bot cascade distribution of the content aims to flood and overwhelm the information space.

Recommendations and Actions Taken

Recommendations: Archive accounts and content to inform further research; share and refine account surfacing techniques to inform further research and monitoring; flag surfaced accounts with relevant platforms for removal.

Repo rt	Topic	Evidence	Authors	Platforms	Logo
N/A	Overload, election	<u>Link</u>	Joe Ondrak, Alliance4Europe; ISD.	X, Bluesky	